

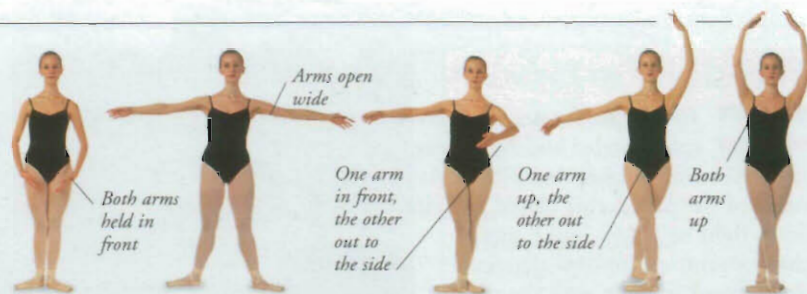
BALLET

B



ONE OF THE MOST beautiful of the arts, ballet is a combination of dance and mime performed to music. Many ballets tell a

story; others are abstract and experiment with form and movement. Ballet began in Italy. It was taken to France in 1533 by Catherine de Médicis, a member of a famous Italian family, who married a French prince. In 1661, Louis XIV founded the first ballet school, L'Academie Royale de Danse. Today, children learn the basics in ballet schools around the world.



First position – heels together, feet turned out.

Second position – heels apart, feet turned out.

Third position – one foot crossed halfway in front of the other.

Fourth position (crossed) – one foot in front of the other.

Fifth position – Feet crossed and touching.

Ballet positions

Every step in ballet makes use of the basic positions. It was at L'Academie Royale de Danse that the five basic positions of the feet were established. To achieve them, the whole leg has to be turned out from the hips. The position of the arms is known as *port de bras*.

Benesh notation

For ballets to survive, the steps must be written down, or notated. One of the most popular notation methods was devised by Rudolf and Joan Benesh in the late 1940s. Symbols represent the position of the hands and feet.



Each line represents a part of the body: top of head; shoulder; waist; knee; floor.

Romantic ballet

In the early 1800s, the Romantic Movement, with its fascination with the supernatural, affected all the arts. One of the most important men in 19th-century ballet was the choreographer August Bournonville. His ballets were influenced by his years in Paris where Romantic ballet began.

Marie Taglione (1804–84) was an Italian ballerina who created the role of *La Sylphide*. She perfected the art of dancing on the tips of her toes, or *en pointe*.



Nijinsky

The Ballets Russes

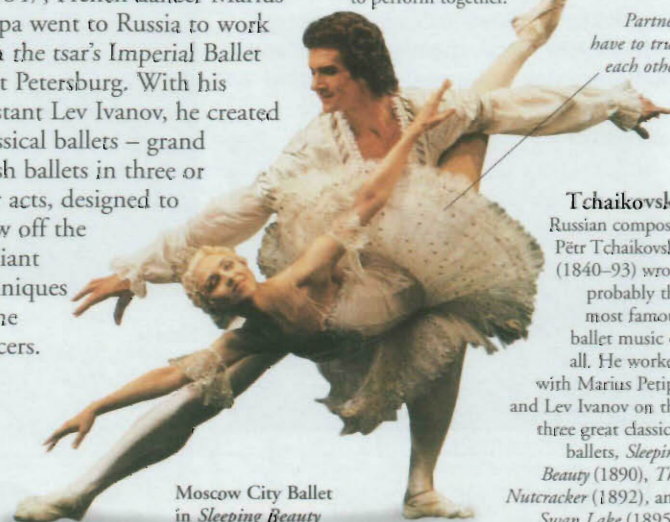
Many Russian choreographers and dancers became bored with Classical ballet. Organized by Serge Diaghilev (1872–1929), they formed the Ballets Russes and toured Europe. The dancers included Vaslav Nijinsky (1890–1950), famous for his jumps.

Ballet in Russia

In 1847, French dancer Marius Petipa went to Russia to work with the tsar's Imperial Ballet in St Petersburg. With his assistant Lev Ivanov, he created Classical ballets – grand lavish ballets in three or four acts, designed to show off the brilliant techniques of the dancers.

Classical ballets all contain dazzling dances for the hero and heroine to perform together.

Partners have to trust each other.



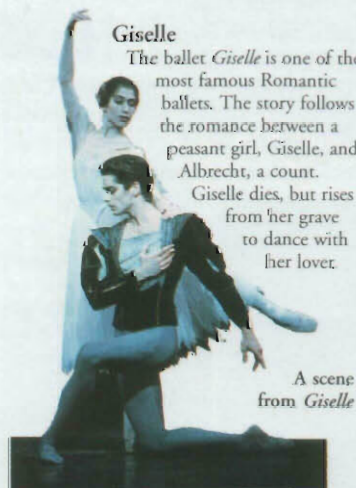
Moscow City Ballet in *Sleeping Beauty*

Tchaikovsky Russian composer Pëtr Tchaikovsky (1840–93) wrote probably the most famous ballet music of all. He worked with Marius Petipa and Lev Ivanov on the three great classical ballets, *Sleeping Beauty* (1890), *The Nutcracker* (1892), and *Swan Lake* (1895).

Giselle

The ballet *Giselle* is one of the most famous Romantic ballets. The story follows the romance between a peasant girl, Giselle, and Albrecht, a count.

Giselle dies, but rises from her grave to dance with her lover.



A scene from *Giselle*

Anna Pavlova

Russian ballerina Anna Pavlova (1881–1931) was the most famous dancer of her time. She danced with the Imperial Ballet, and also toured with the Ballets Russes. She formed her own company and toured all over the world.



Ballet today

Almost every country has its own ballet company. The dancers perform Romantic and Classical ballets, ballets created by the Ballets Russes, and the works of more modern and contemporary choreographers.



New York City Ballet

The New York City Ballet (left) was founded by the Russian choreographer George Balanchine (1904–83). This is his ballet *Apolla*.

The Royal Ballet

Britain's Royal Ballet started as the Vic-Wells Ballet in 1931. It often dances works by past artistic directors Frederick Ashton and Kenneth MacMillan.



A character from Ashton's *Tales of Beatrix Potter*

FIND OUT MORE

ART, HISTORY OF

DANCE

DRAMA

JAZZ

MUSIC

MUSICAL INSTRUMENTS

OPERA

STRAVINSKY, IGOR